



arrived. The original homeland was called *Hawaiiki* but the European explorers renamed it New Zealand. The Maori still have a very strong culture of their own, even though many of them now live a Western

lifestyle. Their numbers are now rising after a long period of decline and there are currently over 500,000 Maori, about 16 percent of the population. The Maori language is also in increasing use.

The *Marae* is often named after an ancestor. The ridgepole that holds the roof symbolizes the spine, with the rafters as ribs. Each rafter has an ancestral lineage carved into it.



THE SPIRITUAL MARAE

The center of every Maori community is the *Marae*—a meeting house with a surrounding courtyard, which may include a church. It is used as a political and ceremonial place where important decisions are made and rituals held. Within the *Marae* the Maori language, *Maoritanga*, is spoken. Even urban communities have a *Marae*.

POI DANCE

The Maori *poi* dance is generally performed by women. A *poi*, which means “ball,” is attached at each end of a piece of flaxen string. The *pois* are then twirled and whirled rhythmically. The design is based on an ancient weapon and the length of them can vary from 1 ft to 3 ft (0.3 m to 1 m). They are swung around the body in various patterns that suggest forces of nature such as birds in flight, waterfalls, or summer rain. The whole effect can be very hypnotic.

The dancers wear flax skirts and traditionally woven bodices or *pari*.



A traditional greenstone, or jade, pendant.